This description of Afghanistan as ‘a passing stage’ would not have escaped the notice of the Indian government. The Bolshevik regime’s relationship with exiled Indian dissidents, some of whom had at one stage or another resided in Kabul, only compounded India’s fears. The Muslim agitator Maulana Barakatullah, for example, had been part of the German–Turkish mission to Afghanistan in 1915, and in 1919 arrived in Moscow claiming to have been specially sent by the new Afghan emir to establish relations with the Soviet government.[134] The Indian revolutionary also tried to assert that ‘the ideas of communism have thoroughly penetrated into Afghanistan and even into neighbouring India’, although both these claims were simply wishful thinking on Barakatullah’s part.[135] The year 1919 also saw the arrival in Moscow of Mahendra Pratap, the head of the ‘Indian Provisional Government’ – an organisation set up in Berlin during the First World War by exiled Indian revolutionaries. After discussions with Lenin, Pratap travelled to Kabul later in the year, where he was joined by Karl Bravin who, being unsuccessful in Persia, was now trying his luck in Afghanistan.[136] The new emir was more than welcoming to these Bolshevik and Indian malcontents, allowing them unlimited freedom of movement and association.[137] Thus, in 1919 it appeared that Afghanistan had the potential to be a hotbed of anti-British intrigue.

Nonetheless, for all the apparent affinity between Afghanistan and Bolshevik Russia, there remained doubt among many in the Indian government that Bolshevism alone was the threat to Britain’s interests some claimed it to be. Just as with Persia, there was scepticism that Bolshevik ideology could take hold in Afghanistan, with its religious and monarchical political structure. H.R.C. Dobbs, chief commissioner of Baluchistan, noted that it was ‘inconceivable that present-day Bolshevism should make any impression on the social structure of Afghanistan’.[138] Hamilton Grant, in his talks with the Afghan delegation during the peace negotiations following the Third Anglo-Afghan War, even expressed amusement at the concept that ‘a State ruled by an autocratic King and supported by an aristocracy’ would ‘amalgamate and work in sympathy with a violent rabble who hold that Kings must be murdered, that Monarchies must be abolished, [and] that aristocracies must be swept away’.[139] While the Times might argue that the civil unrest that had preceded the Amritsar Massacre was a result of a Bolshevik ‘conspiracy’,[140] the Political Department of the